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Brown Creeper

Certhia americana

QUICK STATS

Length	4.7 – 5.5 in (12 – 14 cm)
Wingspan	6.7 – 7.9 in (17 – 20 cm)
Weight	0.2 – 0.4 oz (7 – 10 g)
Lifespan	Up to 5 years (avg. 1–2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Brown Creeper is a master of invisibility — a tiny, streaked brown bird whose bark-patterned plumage renders it nearly indistinguishable from the tree trunks it inhabits. It is the only North American member of the treecreeper family, and its foraging method is unique and instantly recognizable: it lands at the base of a tree trunk and spirals upward in short hops, probing bark crevices with its long, downcurved bill, then drops to the base of the next tree and begins again. Despite being present in wooded areas across much of North America in winter, it is so cryptic that many birders miss it entirely until they learn its thin, high-pitched call.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Brown Creeper breeds in mature coniferous and mixed forests across Canada, the Pacific states, and the Appalachians, and winters widely across the United States wherever mature trees are present. In winter it can be found in deciduous and mixed woodlands, suburban parks, and wooded gardens. It shows a strong preference for large-diameter trees with deeply furrowed bark — oaks, ashes, maples, and conifers — that harbor the insects and spiders it depends on.

DIET & FEEDING

- Spider eggs and spiders extracted from bark crevices
- Insect larvae, pupae, and cocoons hidden under bark
- Beetles, ants, and small insects gleaned from bark surfaces
- Occasionally visits suet feeders — suet smeared on bark is most effective
- Pine seeds taken rarely in winter
- Largely insectivorous year-round — does not visit seed feeders

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

The Brown Creeper's foraging behavior is one of the most specialized of any North American bird. It invariably starts at the base of a tree and works upward in a systematic spiral, using its stiff, pointed tail feathers as a prop — exactly like a woodpecker. When it reaches the upper trunk or a major branch, it drops directly to the base of the next tree and repeats the process. In winter it often joins mixed foraging flocks with chickadees, nuthatches, and kinglets, benefiting from the collective vigilance of the flock while maintaining its own specialized foraging niche on bark surfaces.

NESTING & BREEDING

The Brown Creeper builds a unique hammock-shaped nest of bark strips, mosses, and spider webs tucked behind a slab of loose bark on a dead or dying tree — one of the most unusual nest sites of any North American bird. The female incubates 5–6 white eggs with reddish-brown spots for 13–17 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 13–16 days. One brood per season. The species requires large-diameter trees with loose bark for nesting — a habitat increasingly scarce in managed forests.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Brown Creeper's call is a thin, high-pitched "see" — a single, almost inaudible note that is easy to overlook. Once learned, however, it immediately reveals the presence of this otherwise invisible bird. The song is a sweet, descending series of thin whistles: "see-see-see-sissy-see" — delicate and ethereal, delivered from high in the canopy in spring. Both call and song are at the upper frequency range of human hearing and may be inaudible to some older birders.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining slightly
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The Brown Creeper population is estimated at 6.3 million individuals and has shown modest declines linked to the loss of old-growth and mature second-growth forest with large-diameter trees. It is highly dependent on large trees with deeply furrowed bark for both foraging and nesting. Retaining mature trees and standing dead snags in woodlands and parks is the most effective conservation action for this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Smear suet or peanut butter directly onto rough tree bark — the best attractant
- Brown Creepers rarely use cage feeders — bark-smeared food is key
- Retain large trees with deeply furrowed bark in the yard
- Leave dead snags standing — essential for nesting behind loose bark
- Listen for the thin 'see' call in winter mixed flocks near large trees

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back & crown	Brown with white streaks — bark camouflage
Underparts	White — clean, unmarked
Eyebrow stripe	Bold white supercilium
Rump	Warm rufous-buff — visible in flight
Tail	Long, stiff, pointed — prop against bark
Bill	Long, strongly downcurved, dark

COLOR ME!

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